A NOVICE'S FIELD GUIDE • INDIA EDITION • OCTOBER 2026

What Makes Coffee Great?

Source, variety, processing, roast, freshness and brewing, explained and rated. Plus Indian estates, sourcing costs, an Ahmedabad cafe raw-material model, and the city's coffee places, compared.

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80+
SCA points = specialty

Day 7-30
peak window after roasting

₹24.1-24.8k
arabica parchment / 50 kg (6 Oct 2026)

₹2.0-3.9 L
raw material / month, 200 cups/day

Desk research compiled from public sources available up to 9 Oct 2026. Prices are indicative; ratings are the author's assessments.

How to use this guide

You don't need a trained palate to choose better coffee. You need to know which signals actually predict a good cup, and which are just marketing. This guide follows the coffee from seed to cup. At each stage it explains what to look for, gives the numbers that matter, and rates the options. It then applies all of that to India's estates and to the cost of running a café in Ahmedabad.

1 **Judging a cup** — SCA score, the 10 attributes, where quality comes from

2 **Reading the bag & the beans** — label checklist, green & roasted bean specs

3 **Species, varieties & origins** — what makes one great bean differ from another

4 **Processing** — washed, natural, honey, anaerobic, monsooned

5 **Roast & freshness** — roast levels, temperatures, days off roast

6 **Brewing methods** — espresso, filter kaapi, pour-over and more: specs & ratings

7 **The Indian context** — regions, GI tags, grades, varieties, estates

8 **Costs: estate vs other sources** — market prices, price ladder, sourcing routes

9 **Ahmedabad café raw-material model** — 6 sourcing scenarios, cost per cup

10 **Ahmedabad coffee places, rated** — sources, methods, scores

Executive summary: the 12 things that matter most

- **Quality starts at the farm.** Variety, altitude and ripe-only picking set the ceiling. A roaster can only reveal it, and a barista can only avoid wasting it.
- **Specialty means 80+ points** on the SCA 100-point cupping scale. 85+ is excellent, 90+ is rare. Ask sellers for the score.
- **Buy by roast date, never by expiry date.** Filter coffee peaks about 7-28 days after roasting. Espresso peaks about 12-35 days. Grind just before brewing.
- **Traceability predicts quality.** A bag that names an estate, a variety, an altitude, a process and a harvest is almost always better than one that says "100% premium arabica".
- **Process shapes flavour.** Washed coffees taste clean and bright. Naturals are fruity and heavy. Honey is in between. Anaerobic lots are exciting but polarising.
- **Roast to suit the brew.** Light to medium roasts suit pour-over. Medium to medium-dark suit espresso and milk drinks. Medium-dark to dark suits South Indian filter coffee.
- **Recipe matters:** espresso at 1:2 in 25-32 s and 9 bar. Pour-over at 1:15-1:17, 92-96°C. Water at about 150 ppm TDS. Ahmedabad's hard water *must* be treated.
- **India's strength** is shade-grown arabica that is low in acidity and chocolatey, plus some of the world's best washed robusta. Leading estates such as Ratnagiri and Kerehaklu now make experimental micro-lots that compete internationally.
- **Indian commodity green arabica** costs about ₹550-650/kg (Oct 2026). Traceable estate specialty costs about ₹850-1,100/kg, micro-lots ₹1,500-3,500/kg. Imported green pays about 100% basic customs duty.
- **For a 200-cup/day Ahmedabad café**, raw materials cost about ₹2.0-3.9 lakh a month with Indian beans. Coffee is 50-74% of that, and milk (~₹55k) is the next biggest line.
- **Best value-for-quality route:** buy estate green directly and have it toll-roasted for espresso and cold brew. Add a rotating micro-lot for pour-overs. Use a commodity blend with chicory for filter kaapi.
- **In Ahmedabad**, OCD Culture (multi-roaster slow bar), Blue Tokai and Kaffa (in-house live roastery) are the best places to train your palate (see section 10).

Rating scale used throughout: 9-10 Exceptional | 8-8.9 Excellent | 7-7.9 Good | 6-6.9 Fair / niche | < 6 Weak for this purpose

A note on the ratings

All scores are my assessments, synthesised from published specifications, SCA standards, producer and roaster information and public reviews. They rate suitability for the stated purpose, not moral worth. I have not tasted these coffees or visited the cafés, so treat the scores as a starting map and let your own cupping overrule them.

Numbers to remember

80+ SCA points = specialty	**< 4 wks** since roast date when you buy	**3-7 / 7-14 d** rest before filter / espresso	**18 g → 36 g** espresso, 25-32 s, 9 bar
1:16 pour-over ratio, 92-96°C, ~3 min	**150 ppm** ideal brew-water TDS	**10-12%** green-bean moisture	**15-25%** roast time after first crack
₹550-650 per kg, commodity Indian green arabica	**₹850-1,100** per kg, estate specialty green	**100%** basic customs duty on imported coffee	**≥ 51%** coffee in a coffee-chicory mix (FSSAI)

1 Judging a Cup

What 'good' actually means, and how professionals score it

Professionals judge coffee by **cupping**. Coarsely ground coffee steeps in hot water and is then slurped from a spoon, so that roast and recipe don't hide anything. The Specialty Coffee Association (SCA) form scores ten attributes and adds them up to a 100-point scale. In 2024 the SCA introduced the Coffee Value Assessment (CVA), which keeps *describing* a coffee separate from *liking* it. The 80-point specialty threshold is still the industry's common language.

Attribute	What it is	What a novice should notice
Fragrance / Aroma	Smell of dry grounds, then of the wet brew	Intense and pleasant: fruit, flowers, caramel, cocoa. Not flat, papery or smoky.
Flavour	The main taste and retro-nasal smell	Distinct and specific notes, not just "coffee".
Aftertaste	What lingers after swallowing	Long and sweet, not dry, ashy or astringent.
Acidity	Brightness, as in biting an apple	Juicy and mouth-watering. Sharp, wince-making sourness is a defect.
Body	Weight and texture in the mouth	Skim-milk vs whole-milk feel. Neither is wrong.
Balance	How the parts fit together	Nothing shouts over the rest.
Sweetness	Natural sugar-like fullness	Pleasant without added sugar.
Clean cup	No off-flavours from first sip to finish	No mustiness, ferment, rubber or medicinal notes.
Uniformity	Every cup of the lot tastes the same	Shows careful sorting at the mill.
Overall	The taster's holistic judgement	Would you want a second cup?



Left: the ten SCA cupping attributes. Right: what the total score means.

Where quality comes from: seed to cup

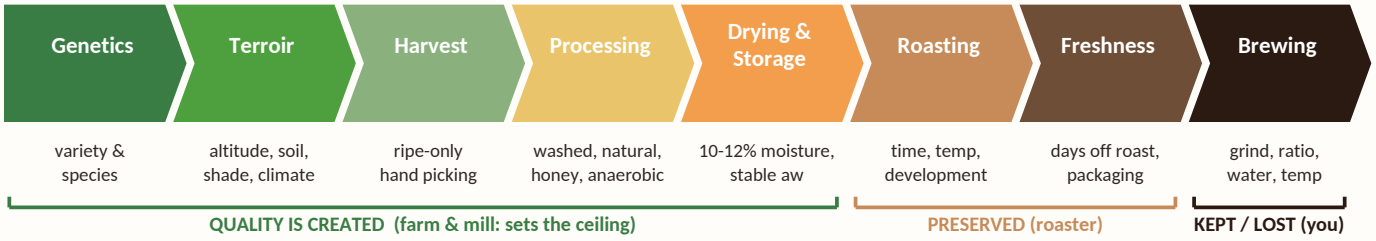
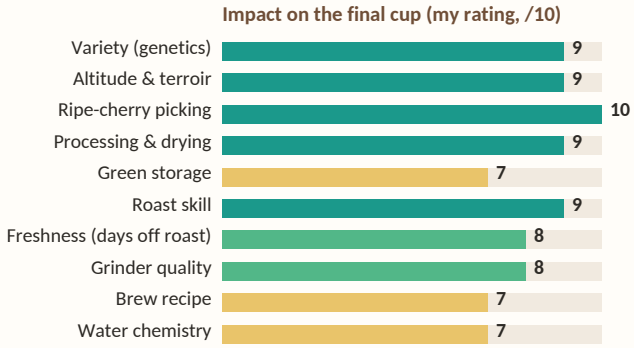


Figure 1. The quality chain. Every stage can only preserve or destroy the potential set by the stages before it.



Why the farm matters most

A roaster cannot add sweetness that unripe cherries never had, and no brewer can remove a fermented defect. So the biggest levers are **genetics, altitude, picking and processing**. Higher altitude means cooler nights, so cherries ripen more slowly and form denser beans with more sugars and acids. That is why altitude is printed on good bags.

What you control

Freshness, grinding and brewing decide whether you taste that potential. A burr grinder matters more than an expensive brewer. Blade grinders give uneven particles that over-extract (bitter) and under-extract (sour) at the same time.

Figure 2. How strongly each factor moves the final cup (author's weighting).

2 Reading the Bag & the Beans

A 60-second checklist you can use in any shop or online listing

The label checklist

Label item	What good looks like	Red flag	Importance
Roast date	Printed date, ideally within 2-4 weeks	Only a 12-month 'best before'	10
Origin detail	Country > region > estate > lot	"Premium blend", origin unnamed	9
Process	Washed / natural / honey / anaerobic named	Not stated	8
Variety	e.g. S.795, Sln 9, Chandragiri, SL28	Just "100% arabica"	7
Altitude	India 1,000 m+; Africa / LatAm 1,400 m+	Missing for a single origin	7
Tasting notes	Specific: jaggery, orange, cocoa nib	Vague: rich, smooth, bold	6
Roast level & use	Matches your brew (filter / espresso)	"Dark" for a delicate micro-lot	8
Packaging	One-way valve, resealable, opaque, N_2 flush	Clear bag, no valve, open bins	8
Whole bean	Whole bean, ground at home or café	Pre-ground (stale in ~30 min)	9
Harvest / crop year	Within the last 12 months	Not stated	6
Score / grade	SCA score (e.g. 84.5), or a grade such as Plantation AA	No quality data	6

Looking at the beans

Green coffee spec (SCA specialty grade)	Target	Why it matters
Primary (Cat. 1) defects	0 in a 350 g sample	full black, full sour, fungus, foreign matter
Secondary (Cat. 2) defects	≤ 5 full defects / 350 g	broken, insect-bitten, unripe, shells
Moisture content	9-13% (ideal 10-12%)	wet = mould risk; dry = flat, papery
Water activity	~0.45-0.60 aw	high aw = ageing and mould
Screen-size uniformity	≤ 5% outside stated size	uneven roast
Quakers (roasted test)	0 in 100 g roasted	unripe beans, peanut taste
Colour & smell	Even blue-green (washed) / yellow-green (natural)	faded, musty, chemical

Roasted bean check	Good sign	Warning
Colour uniformity	Even, no pale beans	mixed lots or poor sorting
Surface oil	Dry or matte for light-medium roasts	oily light roast = stale
Shape	Whole beans, few chips	scorched tips, craters
Pale 'quakers'	None	underripe cherries
Aroma when opened	Sweet, caramel, fruit, cocoa	cardboard, rancid, smoky
Sound / feel	Beans crack crisply when bitten	soft or chewy = stale/humid

Novice shortcut

If a bag shows (1) a roast date under 4 weeks old, (2) a named estate and process, and (3) a valve, you have already filtered out about 80% of the bad coffee sold in India. Smell the beans: a sweet, fruity or chocolatey smell that fills the room is a good sign. A smell like old newspaper is not.

What to see in the cup

What to look at	Good sign	Problem sign (and likely cause)
Espresso crema	Hazelnut to reddish-brown, 2-4 mm, 'tiger' flecks, lasts 1-2 min	Pale, thin, vanishes fast (stale or under-extracted). Very dark with a white hole (over-extracted, too hot)
Espresso flow	Starts at ~6-8 s, honey-like stream, 25-32 s total	Gushing in under 15 s (grind too coarse). Dripping past 40 s (too fine)
Milk foam	Glossy, wet-paint microfoam with no visible bubbles; sweet taste	Stiff dry froth, big bubbles, scalded smell (over 65°C)
Pour-over / black	Clear, translucent amber to mahogany; aroma rises as it cools	Murky, oily film or sludge (fines, dirty gear); flat smell
Filter kaapi	Thick, dark decoction; frothy top after metering; aroma before sugar	Thin and brown-grey (stale or over-diluted); woody or medicinal (too much chicory)
As it cools	Sweetness and fruit become clearer, which is a sign of quality	Turns harsher or more bitter as it cools, a sign of defects or a dark roast hiding them

3 Species, Varieties & Origins

Why two 'great' coffees can taste nothing alike

Spec	Arabica (C. arabica)	Robusta (C. canephora)
Chromosomes / pollination	44, self-pollinating	22, cross-pollinating
Typical altitude (global)	900-2,200 m	0-900 m
Typical altitude (India)	~1,000-1,600 m	~500-1,000 m
Caffeine (dry bean)	1.2-1.5%	2.2-2.7%
Sugars (sucrose)	6-9%	3-7%
Lipids (aroma carriers)	15-17%	10-11.5%
Chlorogenic acids (bitterness)	5.5-8%	7-10%
Bean shape	Oval, S-shaped crease	Rounder, straight crease
Cup character	Acidity, aroma, sweetness, complexity	Body, crema, cocoa, earthy, more bitter
Share of India crop 2025-26 (est.)	~29% (118,125 t)	~71% (284,875 t)
Best uses	Pour-over, specialty espresso	Espresso blends (crema), filter kaapi

Specialty potential (my rating)

Type	Score
Arabica, high grown	9.5
Arabica, low grown	7
Fine robusta (washed, India)	7.5
Commodity robusta	5

Robusta isn't 'bad coffee'. A carefully washed Indian robusta (e.g. Kaapi Royale) scores in the 80s on the Fine Robusta scale. It gives filter kaapi and espresso blends their thick body and crema.

Varieties: the 'grape' of coffee

Variety	Parentage	Signature cup	Where	Cup potential
Gesha / Geisha	Ethiopian landrace, made famous in Panama	Jasmine, bergamot, peach, tea-like	Panama, Colombia, Ethiopia	10
Ethiopian landraces	Wild & heirloom diversity	Floral, citrus, berry	Ethiopia	9.5
SL28 / SL34	Kenya, Scott Labs (1930s)	Blackcurrant, grapefruit, juicy	Kenya	9.5
Bourbon	Natural mutation, Réunion	Sweet, round, caramel	Rwanda, Burundi, LatAm	8.5
Typica	Original lineage	Clean, delicate, sweet	Jamaica, Hawaii, Indonesia	8
Sln 9 (India)	Tafarikela (Ethiopian) × Hibrido de Timor	Floral/fruit potential; Fine Cup Award 2002	Karnataka, Tamil Nadu	8
S.795 (Sln 3, India)	S.288 × Kent's	Mild, cocoa, spice; bold bean	India's most-planted arabica	7.5
Chandragiri (Sln 13)	Villa Sarchi × HdT, released 2007	Clean, bold; rust-tolerant	Karnataka	7.5
Caturra / Catuai	Dwarf Bourbon / Mundo Novo cross	Bright but simpler	LatAm; Catuai in India	7
Catimor / Cauvery	Caturra × HdT	High yield, plainer cup	India & Asia	6
Robusta S.274 / CxR	Indian robusta selections	Cocoa, nut, heavy body	Kerala, Kodagu	6.5

What makes one great bean different from another great bean?

Two 90-point coffees can be opposites: a Kenyan that tastes like blackcurrant juice, and a Brazilian natural like a hazelnut chocolate bar. Excellence is about **clarity, sweetness and a distinctive, defect-free identity**, not one flavour. Identity comes from four layers: **genetics** (Gesha's florals, SL28's blackcurrant), **terroir** (altitude, latitude, soil, shade), **processing** (washed clarity vs natural fruit), and **roast**.

Origin	Altitude	Signature cup	What makes it different	Cost	Rating
Ethiopia (Yirgacheffe, Guji)	1,800-2,300 m	Jasmine, lemon, bergamot, berry	Birthplace of arabica; unmatched genetic diversity	₹₹₹	9.5
Kenya (Nyeri, Kirinyaga)	1,500-2,100 m	Blackcurrant, grapefruit, juicy	SL28/SL34, volcanic soils, meticulous washing	₹₹₹	9.5
Panama (Boquete Geisha)	1,500-1,900 m	Jasmine, peach, tea-like	The Gesha variety; record auction prices	₹₹₹₹₹	10
Colombia (Huila, Nariño)	1,500-2,100 m	Caramel, red apple, citrus	Microclimates; near year-round harvests	₹₹	8.5
Brazil (Cerrado, S. Minas)	800-1,300 m	Nut, cocoa, low acidity	Consistent naturals; the world's espresso base	₹	7
Sumatra	1,100-1,600 m	Earthy, cedar, herbal, heavy	Unique wet-hulling (giling basah)	₹₹	7
India, high-grown arabica	1,000-1,600 m	Cocoa, spice, jaggery, mild citrus	Two-tier shade, pepper and cardamom intercropping, low acidity	₹-₹₹	8
India, Monsooned Malabar	n/a (process)	Earthy, spicy, very low acid	Monsoon-wind ageing; GI-protected and unique to India	₹	7

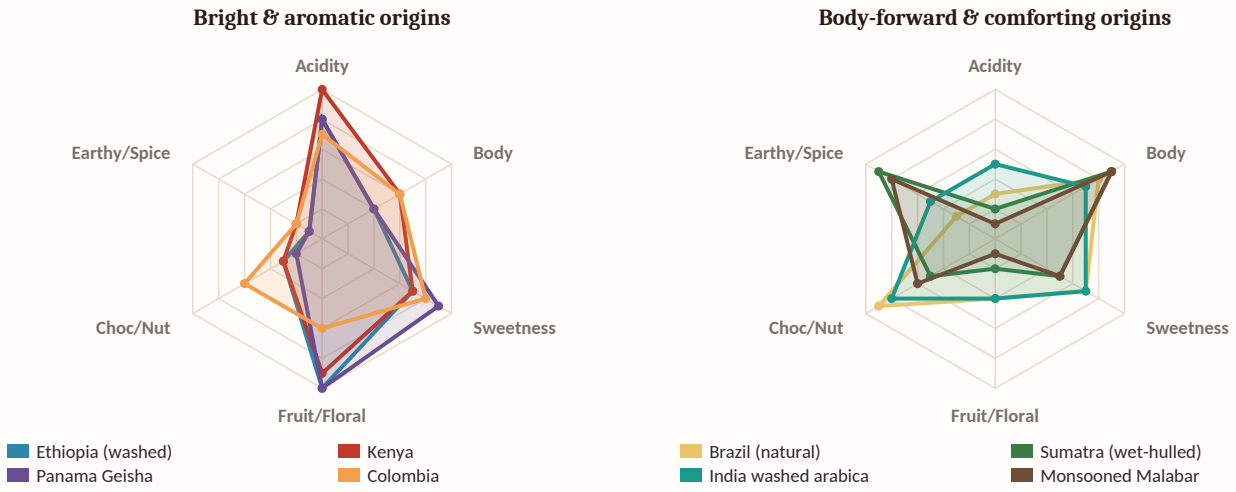


Figure 3. Typical flavour profiles (0-10, author's synthesis of common cupping notes). Individual lots vary.

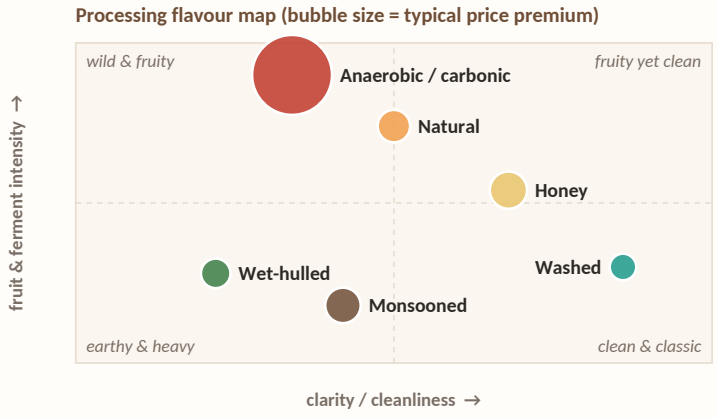
Why Indian coffee tastes the way it does

India grows coffee at 10-13°N under a two-tier canopy of silver oak and native trees, often next to pepper, cardamom and oranges. Shade and a monsoon climate give slower, even ripening, which produces **full body, low-to-medium acidity and chocolate, spice and jaggery notes**. That profile is ideal for milk drinks and filter kaapi. The newer wave of experimental processing (honey, anaerobic, carbonic maceration) is adding fruit-forward lots that compete with Central American coffees.

4 Processing

How the fruit is removed: the biggest flavour switch after variety

Method	How it works	Flavour effect	Risk	Price vs washed	Novice appeal	Café fit
Washed (wet)	Skin & pulp removed, fermented 12-48 h, washed, dried	Clean, bright, terroir-forward	High consistency; needs water	Baseline	9	9
Honey / pulped natural	Pulp off, sticky mucilage left on to dry (yellow/red/black)	Sweet, rounded, softer acidity	Medium	+10-25%	8.5	8.5
Natural (dry)	Whole cherry dried 2-4 weeks on beds or patios	Fruity, winey, heavy body	Over-ferment risk	+0-20%	8	8
Anaerobic / carbonic	Fermented in sealed tanks or CO_2 before drying	Intense, boozy, tropical, cinnamon	Variable; polarising	+30-150%	7	6.5
Monsooned (India)	Naturals exposed to monsoon winds ~12-16 weeks; beans swell, turn pale gold	Very low acid, earthy, spicy, heavy	Consistent	GI premium	7	7.5
Wet-hulled	Parchment hulled at high moisture (Indonesia)	Earthy, herbal, low acid	Idiosyncratic	None	6.5	6



How to read the map

The less fruit flesh that stays on the bean while it dries, the cleaner and more 'terroir-transparent' the cup. Leaving fruit on (honey, natural) or fermenting without oxygen (anaerobic) adds sweetness, fruit and body, at the cost of clarity and with more risk of ferment defects.

Picking for a beginner

Start with a **washed** Indian estate coffee, which shows the 'baseline'. Then try a **honey** or **natural** lot from the same estate to taste what processing does. Try anaerobic lots last, as a dessert-like experience.

In Indian trade terms, **'Plantation'** means washed arabica, **'Cherry'** means natural (dry-processed) arabica or robusta, and **'Parchment'** (for robusta) means washed robusta.

Figure 3b. Where each process sits between clarity and fruit intensity (author's synthesis).

5 Roast & Freshness

Turning a seed into flavour, and how fast it fades

Roasting is controlled cooking. Water is driven out (drying), sugars and amino acids brown (Maillard reactions and caramelisation), and the bean cracks open as steam and CO_2 escape (**first crack**). The time after first crack, called **development**, should usually be 15-25% of total roast time. Too little tastes grassy and sour. Too much tastes flat and roasty.

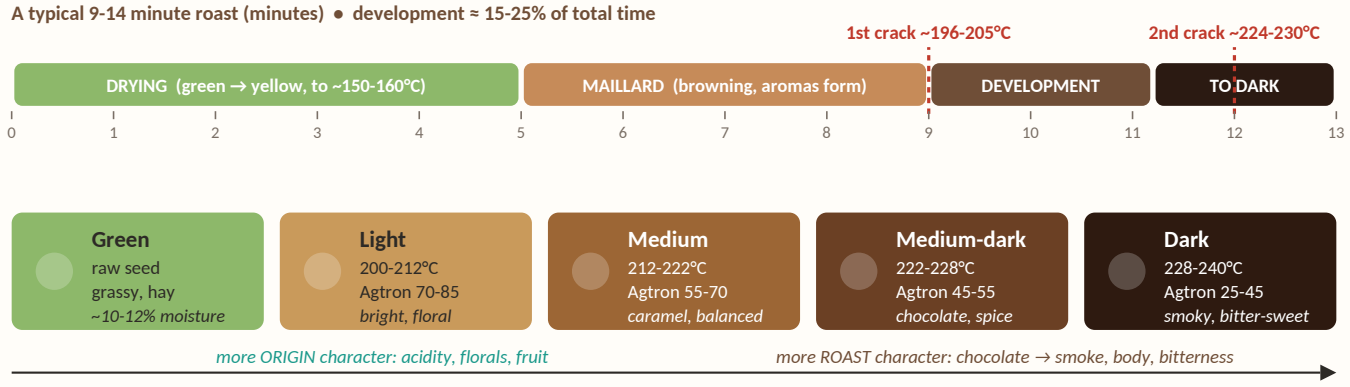


Figure 4. The roast spectrum: phases, crack temperatures and approximate Agtron colour readings (higher number = lighter).

Roast level	Drop temp	Agtron	Wt. loss	Surface	Flavour	Pour-over	Espresso	Milk drinks	Filter kaapi
Light (Cinnamon-City)	200-212°C	70-85	11-13%	Dry	Bright acidity, floral, tea-like	9	5	4	2
Medium (City+-Full City)	212-222°C	55-70	13-16%	Dry	Balanced: caramel, fruit + cocoa	8	9	8	6
Medium-dark (Full City+)	222-228°C	45-55	16-18%	Oil spots	Chocolate, spice, heavy body	5	8	9	9
Dark (Vienna-French)	228-240°C	25-45	18-22%	Oily	Smoky, bitter-sweet; origin fades	2	5	7	8

Columns on the right: my suitability rating of each roast level for each use.

Freshness: the 'days off roast' rule

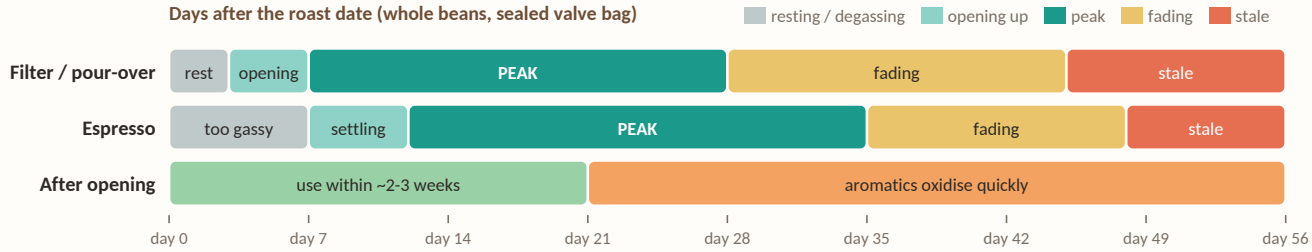


Figure 5. Freshly roasted coffee gives off CO_2 for days. That disturbs extraction, so coffee needs to rest before it peaks, and it then slowly loses aromatics.

- **Rest:** 3-7 days for filter, 7-14 days for espresso. Darker roasts degas faster and peak sooner.
- **Store** whole beans airtight, opaque, cool and dry. **Not in the fridge**, because of condensation and odours. Freeze only sealed single-use portions.
- **Grind to order.** Ground coffee loses much of its aroma within 15-30 minutes.
- **Café rule:** order weekly, keep no more than 2-3 weeks of stock, and rotate first-in, first-out. Ahmedabad's summer heat (40°C+) speeds staling, so keep stock air-conditioned.

6 Brewing Methods

Specs, how each changes the cup, and how they rate

Every brew method is a different way to control the same three things: **how much coffee dissolves** (extraction, ideally 18-22% of the grounds' mass), **how strong the drink is** (TDS, total dissolved solids) and **what gets filtered out** (oils and fines). Paper filters give clarity, metal and immersion give body, and pressure gives intensity.

Method	Ratio / dose	Grind	Water	Contact time	Force	Result
Espresso	1:2 (18 g → 36 g)	200-300 µm	90-96°C	25-32 s	9 bar	8-12% TDS; syrupy, crema
South Indian filter	~20-25 g : 150 ml decoction; then 1 : 2-3 with milk	350-550 µm	~95-100°C	15-30 min drip	Gravity	Thick decoction; sweet, frothy milk coffee
V60 pour-over	1:15-1:17 (15 g : 250 g)	500-800 µm	92-96°C	2:30-3:30	Gravity	1.15-1.35% TDS; clarity, florals
Chemex	1:15-1:17 (30 g : 500 g)	700-900 µm	93-96°C	4-5 min	Gravity	Very clean, light body
AeroPress	1:11-1:16 (15 g : 200 g)	400-700 µm	80-95°C	1-2.5 min	Hand press	Forgiving, versatile
French press	1:12-1:15 (30 g : 450 g)	900-1,200 µm	93-96°C	4 min + settle	Immersion	Heavy body, some silt
Moka pot	~1:7-1:10	300-500 µm	Start with hot water	3-5 min	~1-1.5 bar	Strong, heavy; 'stovetop espresso'
Cold brew	1:5-1:8 concentrate, then dilute	1,000-1,400 µm	4-22°C	12-20 h	Immersion	Low acid, chocolatey; batchable
Turkish / cezve	1:10	<100 µm	Near boil	2-3 min	-	Thick, unfiltered

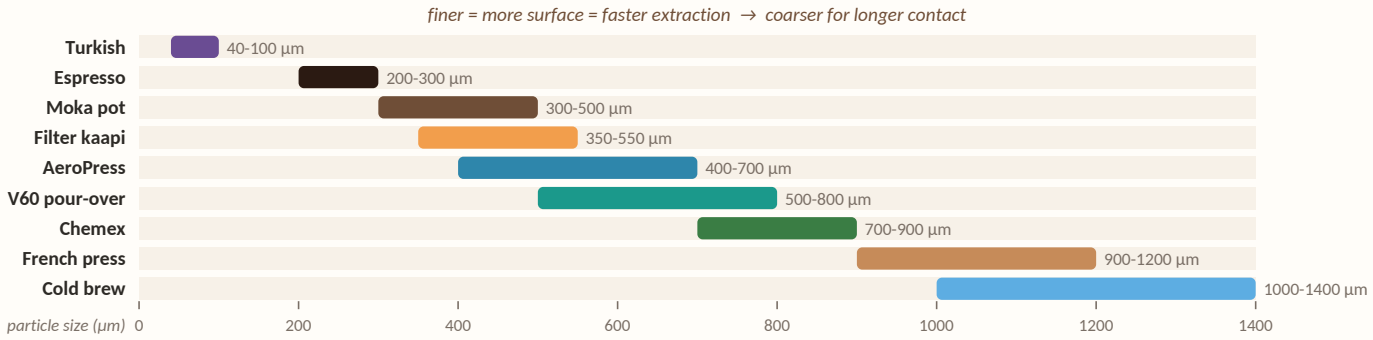


Figure 6. Approximate grind-size ranges by method. Burr grinders vary, so dial in by taste.

Method	Flavour clarity	Body	Ease (novice)	Consistency	Café throughput	Equipment cost (indicative)	Overall
Espresso machine	6	9	3	7	10	₹2.5-15 L (2-group commercial)	8.5
V60 pour-over	10	5	6	7	4	₹1,500-4,000	9
Chemex	10	3	6	7	4	₹4,000-7,000	8
AeroPress	8	6	9	9	5	₹3,000-4,500	8.5
South Indian filter	4	8	8	7	7	₹400-2,000	8
Cold brew	6	7	9	9	9	₹1,000-5,000	8
French press	5	9	10	8	4	₹800-3,000	7.5
Moka pot	4	8	7	6	3	₹1,500-4,000	6.5

Brew-method ratings. L = lakh. 'Overall' weighs cup quality more heavily than convenience.

Taste-fault decoder: fix the cup by taste

Sour, thin, salty: under-extracted. Grind finer, brew hotter or longer. **Bitter, dry, hollow:** over-extracted. Grind coarser or shorten the brew. **Ashy, burnt:** roasted too dark. **Papery, flat:** stale beans. **Peanut or cereal:** unripe 'quaker' beans. **Chalky, dull:** water too hard.

Deep dive: South Indian filter coffee (kaapi)

Equipment: a two-chamber steel or brass filter, plus a dabara and tumbler for 'metering' (pouring from a height to froth).

Beans: traditionally peaberry or Plantation A arabica, often with some robusta for body. Medium-dark to dark roast, ground fine-medium.

Chicory: adds body, colour and a woody bitterness and makes the coffee go further. FSSAI rules require a coffee-chicory mix to contain **at least 51% coffee**, and the label must state the split. Only chicory-free coffee may be called 'pure'. Good cafés use 80:20 or 70:30.

Method: put 20-25 g of powder in the upper chamber, press lightly with the disc, add about 150 ml of just-boiled water and wait 15-20 min. Mix 1 part decoction with 2-3 parts hot full-cream milk, sweeten, and meter until frothy.

Quality cues: the decoction should be dark, thick and aromatic, and never re-boiled. If it tastes medicinal or woody, there is too much chicory.

Café rating: 9/10 for Ahmedabad. It is familiar, cheap to make, quick to batch, and has a very high margin.

Espresso machine: specs that matter

Spec	Target
Brew pressure	~9 bar at the group (profiling optional)
Temperature stability	PID control, ±0.5°C; 90-96°C
Boiler design	Multi-boiler or heat-exchanger with good recovery
Groups for ~200 cups/day	2-group commercial + volumetric dosing
Steam	Dry, powerful steam for consistent microfoam
Grinder	On-demand, 64-83 mm flat or large conical burrs; one per bean
Water	Softening / RO + remineralisation (scale kills machines)
Recipe	18 g in → 36 g out in 25-32 s; adjust grind first

Water parameter (SCA)	Acceptable	Target
Total dissolved solids	75-250 mg/L	150 mg/L
Calcium hardness (as $CaCO_3$)	17-85 mg/L	~68 mg/L
Total alkalinity	~40 mg/L	40 mg/L
pH	6.5-7.5	7.0
Sodium	≤ ~10 mg/L	10 mg/L
Chlorine / odour	None	0

Water is about 98% of the cup

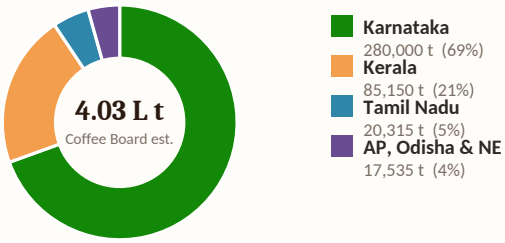
Water that is too hard tastes chalky and flat and scales the machine. Water that is too soft (raw RO) tastes sour and hollow. Borewell water in many parts of Ahmedabad is far harder than the SCA range, and municipal (Narmada-line) supply varies. Test with a ₹300-500 TDS meter, then use RO plus a remineralising cartridge or a blend tap set to about 120-150 ppm. This single fix often improves a café's coffee more than changing the beans.

7 The Indian Context

Where Indian coffee grows, how it is graded, who makes the best

India is a mid-sized producer whose coffee is almost entirely shade-grown. The Coffee Board's post-blossom estimate for 2025-26 was a record **~4.03 lakh tonnes**, about 29% arabica and 71% robusta. A first projection for 2026-27 is ~4.04 lakh t. Karnataka grows roughly 70%, led by Kodagu (~1.30 lakh t) and Chikkamagaluru (~1.04 lakh t).

Production by state, 2025-26 (est.)



Production by species, 2025-26 (est.)

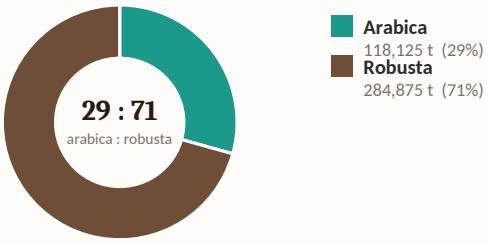


Figure 7. Coffee Board post-blossom estimate for 2025-26 as reported (the AP/Odisha/NE slice is the remainder). USDA's estimate is lower (~3.6 L t).

Growing regions at a glance

Region	State	Altitude (approx.)	Species	GI tag	Cup profile	Specialty rating
Bababudangiri	Karnataka	1,000-1,500 m	Arabica	Yes	Full body, mild acidity, chocolate; India's coffee birthplace	9
Chikmagalur (wider)	Karnataka	800-1,500 m	Both	Yes	Cocoa, spice, citrus hints; most specialty estates	8.5
Biligiri Rangana (BR) Hills	Karnataka	1,000-1,650 m	Arabica	-	Clean, sweet, brighter (e.g. Attikan)	8.5
Pulney Hills	Tamil Nadu	600-2,000 m	Arabica	-	Bright, citrus, medium body	8
Araku Valley	AP / Odisha	900-1,100 m	Arabica	Yes	Sweet, fruity, light cocoa; tribal, organic-leaning	8
Kodagu (Coorg)	Karnataka	750-1,100 m	Robusta-led	Yes	Robusta: cocoa, nut. Arabica: mild, sweet	7.5
Nilgiris / Shevaroys	Tamil Nadu	900-1,500 m	Arabica	-	Fragrant, mellow, balanced	7.5
Manjarabad (Sakleshpur)	Karnataka	900-1,200 m	Both	-	Balanced, chocolatey	7
Wayanad	Kerala	700-1,200 m	Robusta	Yes	Full body, cocoa, earthy (fine robusta)	7
Travancore / Nelliampathy	Kerala	600-1,600 m	Both	-	Mild, nutty, spicy	6.5
Malabar coast (monsooning)	Karnataka / Kerala	Sea level	Process	Yes	Monsooned Malabar: very low acid, earthy	7

GI tags: Coorg Arabica, Chikmagalur Arabica, Bababudangiri Arabica, Araku Valley Arabica and Wayanaad Robusta (registered as a set), plus Monsooned Malabar Arabica and Robusta (registered earlier). Altitude ranges are approximate and vary by source.

Indian grades: size isn't flavour

Indian grade	Type	Bean size	Typical use	Cup score
Plantation PB	Washed arabica peaberry	Round single bean	Prized in filter kaapi	8
Plantation AA	Washed arabica	Screen 18 (~7.0-7.2 mm)	Top export grade	8
Plantation A	Washed arabica	Screen 17 (~6.65 mm)	Core specialty / café base	7.5
Plantation B / C	Washed arabica	Screen 15 / 14 (~6.0 / 5.5 mm)	Blends, filter powder	5
Mysore Nuggets EB	Extra-bold washed arabica	Screen 19 (~7.5 mm)	Premium export (Karnataka)	8
Arabica Cherry AB / PB	Natural arabica	Screen ~15-17	Fruity, heavier	7
Robusta Kaapi Royale	Premium washed robusta	Bold, screen 17+	India's showcase robusta	7.5
Robusta Parchment AB	Washed robusta	Screen ~15-17	Clean, strong; espresso blends	6.5
Robusta Cherry AB	Natural robusta	Screen ~15-17	Filter / instant	5
Monsooned Malabar AA	Monsooned arabica	Screen 18+	Very low acidity	7

*Grades sort beans by **size and defects**. They do not guarantee taste, because an AA can cup at 78 or at 86. Ask for the cup score and the estate as well. Screen sizes are approximate (trade sources differ).*

Indian estates and producers worth knowing

Estate	Region	Profile	Known for	Price	Rating
Ratnagiri Estate	Bababudangiri, Chikmagalur	Patre family since 1927; ~117 ha intercropped with pepper	Pioneer of honey, anaerobic and carbonic-maceration lots in steel tanks	₹₹₹	9
Kerehaklu Estate	Chikmagalur	Farmed since 1953; coffee integrated into native forest	Anoxic / anaerobic peaberry lots	₹₹₹	8.5
Baarbara Estate	Bababudangiri range	Est. 1890s; ~1,170-1,630 m; shade-grown S.795	Washed; reliable and clean: chocolate, mild citrus, nutty	₹₹	8
Attikan Estate	BR Hills	1,200-1,650 m; silver-oak shade; wild fig trees	Washed, honey and experimental; Catuai and Sln 9	₹₹	8
Araku (tribal growers)	Andhra Pradesh / Odisha	GI Araku Valley Arabica; smallholders	Organic-leaning washed and natural lots	₹₹	8
Badra Estates	Chikmagalur	Flavour of India 2025: Best Robusta Natural; 2nd Robusta Washed	Top fine-robusta producer	₹-₹₹	8

Estate ratings reflect reputation and published lot information. Quality varies by harvest and lot, so always cup the current crop. The Coffee Board's annual Flavour of India: Fine Cup Award and its e-auctions of winning lots are a good way to find top producers.

8 Costs: Estate vs Other Sources

From farm-gate prices to a landed kilo of roasted coffee in Ahmedabad

Indian coffee is priced off two references. One is the **ICE arabica 'C' and London robusta futures**: December arabica closed at ~304 US¢/lb on 6 Oct 2026, after a 52-week range of $2.44-4.23/lb. The other is **local trade quotes** per 50 kg bag in the producing districts. Specialty lots trade at a negotiated premium on top of these.

Karnataka trade prices per 50 kg bag, 6 Oct 2026

source: daily market reports

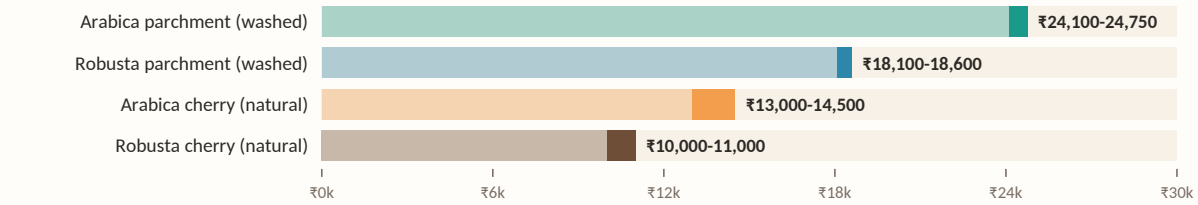
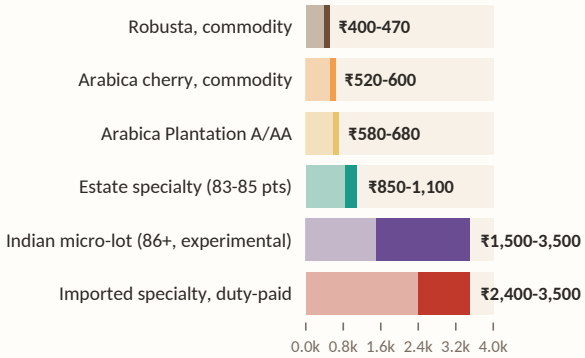


Figure 8. Raw parchment and dried cherry, before hulling. Parchment yields ~80% clean green coffee and dried cherry ~50%, so the green-coffee cost works out to about ₹600-620/kg (arabica parchment), ₹520-580 (arabica cherry), ₹450-465 (robusta parchment) and ₹400-440 (robusta cherry), before curing, grading and freight.

Green coffee price ladder (₹/kg, Oct 2026 estimates)



Roasted coffee landed in Ahmedabad (₹/kg)

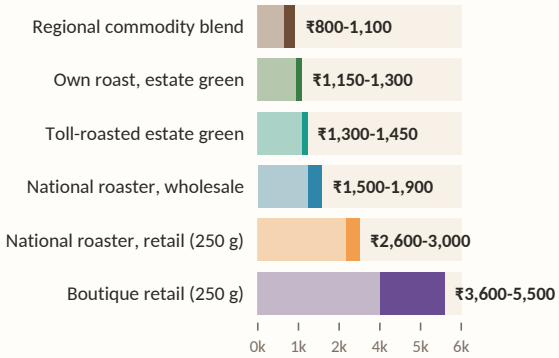


Figure 9. Price ladders. Market listings in May-Sept 2026 showed bulk Chikmagalur green arabica at ~₹450-600/kg. Retail examples: Blue Tokai single estates ₹700-750 per 250 g, Subko ₹895-1,369 per 250 g. Roasting loses 13-18% of the weight, which is built into the roasted figures. Estate-specialty and micro-lot figures are my estimates of negotiated prices.

Imported green (illustrative)	₹/kg
CIF value (specialty at ~$5.5/lb, ₹88/$, + freight)	1,125
Basic customs duty @ 100%	1,125
Social welfare surcharge @ 10% of duty	113
IGST @ 5% on the total	118
Landed (before clearing and agent fees)	~2,480

Why imported beans cost so much more

Unroasted coffee (HS 0901.11) attracts a **100% basic customs duty** plus surcharges. That roughly **doubles** the landed cost of an Ethiopian or Colombian lot. It is why Indian cafés serving imported single origins charge ₹400+ for a pour-over, and why **Indian estate coffee is the value-for-quality sweet spot**. Tariff lines are from secondary aggregators, so confirm current rates with CBIC or a customs broker before importing.

Sourcing routes compared

Route	How it works	₹/kg roasted, landed	Quality control	Consistency	Traceability	Ease / low MOQ	Overall
A. Regional roaster, commodity blend	Buy roasted Plantation/robusta blends locally	800-1,100	4	9	3	9	5.5
B. National specialty roaster (wholesale)	B2B supply from a national specialty brand	1,500-1,900	8	9	9	9	8
C. Estate green + toll roasting	Buy green direct from an estate; a contract roaster roasts to your profile	1,300-1,450	8	7	10	6	8.5
D. Estate green + own roaster	In-house 2-5 kg roaster (capex & skill needed)	1,150-1,300 + capex	9	6	10	3	8
E. Curing works / trader green	Plantation A / Cherry AB from curers, roasted by you or a toll roaster	850-1,000	5	7	4	7	6.5
F. Imported specialty	Importer or roaster offering Ethiopia / Colombia etc.	3,500-5,000	9	8	8	7	6

Estate-to-estate differences: Ratnagiri-style experimental micro-lots cost 2-4× a reliable washed S.795 estate lot like Baarbara. Pay that premium only for pour-over menus, where customers can taste it. In milk drinks a clean washed estate lot or a fine robusta blend gives better value.

9 Ahmedabad Café: Raw-Material Model

Six sourcing strategies for a 200-beverage-a-day specialty café

Drink (menu mix)	Share	Cups / month	Coffee dose	Milk bought
Milk espresso drinks	50%	3,000	18 g	230 ml
Espresso / Americano	12%	720	18 g	-
Pour-over / manual brew	10%	600	16 g	-
Cold brew	13%	780	22 g	-
South Indian filter kaapi	15%	900	10 g	130 ml

Model assumptions

200 drinks a day × 30 days = 6,000 drinks a month. +6% coffee for dial-in and purges, +~15% milk for steaming loss. Milk is full-cream at ₹68/L (Amul Gold MRP ₹70/L after the May 2026 revision, less a trade margin). 40% of drinks are takeaway at ₹9 per cup set. Sugar and syrups average ₹2.5 per drink. Water, filter papers and cleaning chemicals ₹9,000 a month. Filter kaapi uses an 80:20 coffee-chicory blend at ₹750/kg in every scenario. Excludes rent, staff, food and equipment.

Scenario	₹/kg roasted (main / pour-over)	Coffee / mo	Milk / mo	Other / mo	Total / month	Per drink	Coffee share
A. Commodity blend (regional roaster)	950	102k	55k	46k	₹2.02 L	₹34	50%
B. National specialty, wholesale	1,700	176k	55k	46k	₹2.77 L	₹46	64%
C. Estate green, toll-roasted	1,375	144k	55k	46k	₹2.44 L	₹41	59%
D. Estate green, own roaster*	1,225	129k	55k	46k	₹2.29 L	₹38	56%
E. All Indian micro-lots, toll-roasted	2,850	290k	55k	46k	₹3.91 L	₹65	74%
F. Imported specialty, roasted	4,500	454k	55k	46k	₹5.55 L	₹92	82%
Recommended hybrid: C + micro-lot pour-over	1,375 / 2,850	159k	55k	46k	₹2.59 L	₹43	61%

*Coffee needed: ~99 kg roasted beans + ~9.5 kg filter blend per month; milk ~807 L. *Scenario D excludes roaster capex (typically several lakh rupees), gas and the roaster's time.*

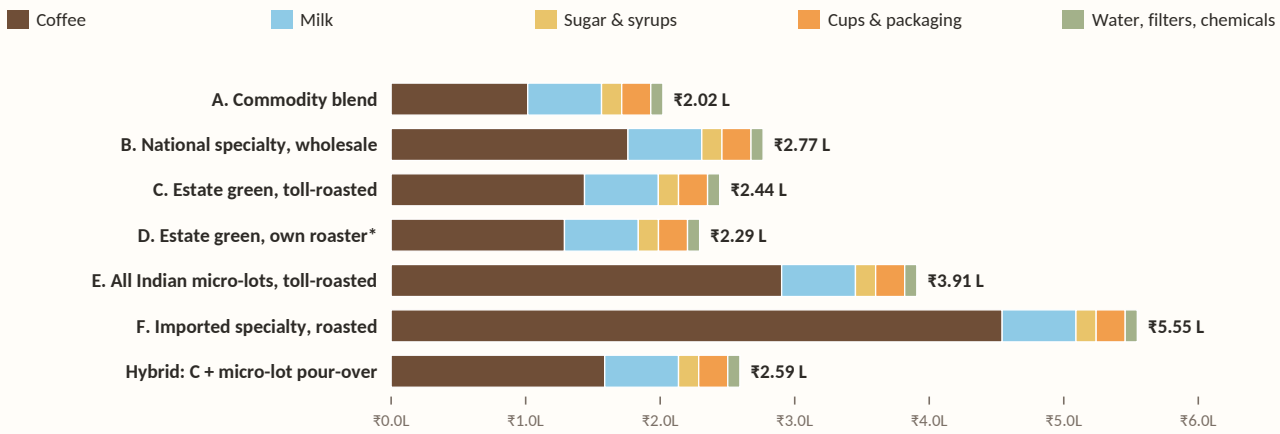


Figure 10. Monthly raw-material cost by scenario (L = lakh). Moving from commodity to good estate coffee adds only about ₹7-12 per drink.

Per-drink economics (recommended hybrid)

Drink (hybrid sourcing)	Coffee	Milk	Sweet + pack	Raw cost	Typical Ahd menu price	Beverage cost %
Cappuccino / latte	₹26	₹16	₹6	₹48	₹220-280	19%
Espresso / Americano	₹26	-	₹5	₹31	₹160-220	16%
V60 pour-over (micro-lot)	₹48	-	₹8	₹56	₹300-400	16%
Cold brew	₹32	-	₹8	₹40	₹240-320	14%
Filter kaapi	₹8	₹9	₹6	₹22	₹80-140	20%

Menu prices are indicative for Ahmedabad specialty cafés (about ₹500-1,500 for two, per listings). A beverage cost under ~25% leaves room for rent and staff.

Recommendations

- **Espresso and cold brew:** one or two washed estate lots (Chikmagalur / BR Hills, S.795 or Sln 9, 83-85 pts) bought green and toll-roasted medium. Add 10-20% fine washed robusta (Kaapi Royale) to the house blend for body and crema in milk drinks.
- **Pour-over bar:** rotate one micro-lot a month (honey, natural or anaerobic from Ratnagiri / Kerehaklu-type producers). Buy 15-30 kg at a time and price it as a premium 'flight'.
- **Filter kaapi:** Plantation A/PB plus robusta, roasted medium-dark, 80:20 with chicory. It is cheap, loved in Gujarat, and has the highest margin on the menu.

- **Lock in prices:** green coffee keeps 6-12 months in GrainPro bags. Contract part of the year's needs at harvest (Dec-Mar), and roast weekly to keep stock fresh.
- **Risk check:** a 20% rise in coffee prices adds about ₹5 per drink in the hybrid model. Milk (about ₹55k a month) is the second-biggest line, so size milk pitchers to the drink to cut steaming waste.

10 Ahmedabad Coffee Places, Rated

Who serves what, how it's brewed, and where to train your palate

Ratings are based on public information (sourcing disclosures, brew menus, roasting set-up), aggregated listings and reviews from District, Swiggy and Zomato, and press coverage up to Oct 2026. I could not taste the coffee. **Score = 25% sourcing transparency + 20% roast freshness/control + 20% brew-method range + 20% review sentiment + 15% value.**

Place	Area	Beans / source	Roasting	Brew methods & signatures	For two	Public rating	My score
OCD Culture	Bodakdev	Multi-roaster 'deep bean menu'; rotating new / guest Indian roasters	Curates guest roasts	V60, AeroPress, iced pour-over, espresso; OCD Special Latte	~₹500	4.3-4.5	8.3
Blue Tokai Coffee Roasters	CG Road (CG Square)*	Direct-sourced Indian single estates (e.g. Attikan, Sandalwood); 100% arabica	Own roasteries (national)	Espresso, pour-over, coffee flights, cold brew	est. ₹700-900	n/a	8.3
Kaffa Coffee Roasters	Vastrapur / Ambawadi; Brewed by Kaffa (Thaltej); KOMO	In-house roasted; origins not publicly detailed	Live roastery on site (one of the city's earliest)	Espresso, extensive manual-brew menu, cold brew; French Vanilla Latte, Litchi Cold Brew	₹1,400	4.5	7.6
Mainline Coffee	Navrangpura	Not publicly specified	Buys in (roaster not named)	Manual brew bar; Barrel-Aged Cold Brew, Caramel Iced Latte	₹500-800	4.6-4.8	7.4
Roastery Cultúr	Bodakdev (+ 2 outlets)	Locally sourced (Indian) beans; specifics not published	Own third-wave roasting	Espresso, pour-over; Café con Leche, cinnamon cappuccino	₹800-1,500	4.6	7.3
Third Wave Coffee	CG Road, Prahlad Nagar, airport	100% arabica from ~15 Indian estates, mostly Karnataka	Central roasting (Bengaluru)	Espresso & milk drinks, cold brew, some pour-over	est. ₹700-900	n/a	7.2
Mleko	Navrangpura	'100% specialty arabica' (roaster not named)	Buys in	Espresso focus, 24-hr cold brew; bakery	est. ₹600-800	n/a	7
Fick's Coffee	Bodakdev	Not publicly specified	Buys in	Specialty espresso bar; Kafir Lime Espresso, Iced Salted Caramel Latte	₹1,400	4.5	6.7
Grace Coffee Co.	Bodakdev	Not publicly specified	Buys in	Self-service; OG Grace Cold Brew; late-night	₹500	4.6	6.7
Tochico Specialty Coffee Roasters	Ambli	Not yet published (new)	Neighbourhood roastery	Espresso drinks; Spanish Latte	₹2,100	new	6.5
Starbucks (Tata Starbucks)	Several outlets	Global blends + India Estates Blend from Tata Coffee's Coorg & Chikmagalur estates	Centrally roasted; dark-roast house style	Espresso, milk and Frappuccino drinks; tall cappuccino ~₹335	est. ₹800-1,000	n/a	6.2

Place	Sourcing	Roast	Brew range	Reviews	Value
OCD Culture	8	7.5	9	8.5	9
Blue Tokai Coffee Roasters	9.5	8	8.5	8	7
Kaffa Coffee Roasters	6	9	8	8.5	6.5
Mainline Coffee	5	7	8.5	9	8.5
Roastery Cultúr	6	8.5	7.5	8.5	6
Third Wave Coffee	7	7.5	7	7.5	7
Mleko	5.5	7	7	8.5	7.5
Fick's Coffee	5	7	7	8.5	6.5
Grace Coffee Co.	4.5	6.5	6	8.5	9
Tochico Specialty Coffee Roasters	5.5	8	6.5	7	5.5
Starbucks (Tata Starbucks)	6.5	6	5.5	7.5	5.5

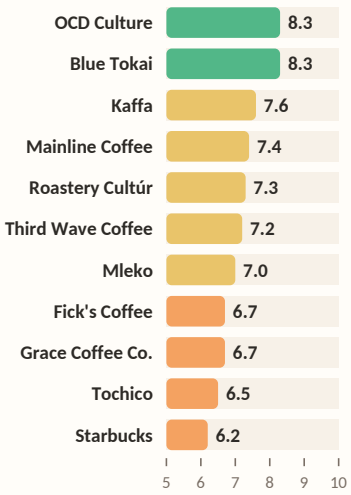


*Figure 11. Sub-scores (left) and weighted overall score (right). Public ratings are aggregator stars at the time of research ('n/a' = not found). 'For two' is the listed price; 'est.' = author's estimate. *Blue Tokai's CG Square listing is undated, so confirm it is open. Tochico is too new for a stable rating.*

How a novice should use Ahmedabad's cafés

Week 1, OCD Culture: order the same coffee as a V60 and as an AeroPress, then two different roasters' beans side by side. You'll learn what 'brew method' and 'origin' taste like. **Week 2, Blue Tokai:** do a coffee flight (washed vs natural vs honey) and read the estate cards. **Week 3, Kaffa:** watch the live roaster and ask for the roast date, then taste an espresso black before a latte. **Week 4:** compare a Starbucks dark-roast cappuccino with a specialty cappuccino. The difference in sweetness and bitterness is the lesson.

Glossary for beginners

Term	Meaning
Agtron	Instrument reading of roast colour; higher = lighter.
Cupping	Standard tasting protocol used to score coffee.
Decoction	Concentrated filter-kaapi extract, mixed with milk.
Degassing	CO_2 release after roasting; why beans need rest.
Development	Roast time after first crack.
Extraction yield	% of the grounds dissolved into the cup (aim 18-22%).
Fine Robusta	Specialty-graded robusta (Q-Robusta 80+).
Micro-lot	Small, separately processed batch from one plot or day.

Term	Meaning
Parchment	Papery husk around washed beans; also India's term for washed robusta.
Peaberry (PB)	Single round bean in a cherry; prized for filter coffee.
Q Grader	Licensed professional coffee taster.
Quaker	Pale, unripe bean that tastes like peanut or cereal.
Screen size	Bean size in 1/64-inch steps (screen 18 ≈ 7.1 mm).
TDS	Total dissolved solids: the strength of the brew.
Toll roasting	Paying a roaster to roast your own green coffee.

Your 30-day palate plan

- **Days 1-7:** buy a washed Indian estate coffee and a natural one, both medium roast, from the same roaster. Brew both the same way. Note acidity, body and sweetness.
- **Days 8-14:** brew one coffee three ways (V60, French press, filter kaapi) and see how the method changes body and clarity.
- **Days 15-21:** taste the same bean at day 3, day 10 and day 30 after roasting to learn what freshness tastes like.
- **Days 22-30:** compare an Indian micro-lot with an imported Ethiopian, then cup three coffees blind and rank them before reading the labels.

Sources & method

Specialty Coffee Association: cupping protocol and score bands, green grading (350 g defect count), water quality standard, Coffee Value Assessment (2024).

Coffee Board of India / reported via AgroSpectrum (Sept 2025): 2025-26 post-blossom crop estimate (4.03 L t; arabica 118,125 t; robusta 284,875 t; state split). StoneX: 2026-27 first forecast and USDA comparison.

Kirehalli daily coffee market reports (Oct 2026): Karnataka parchment and cherry prices per 50 kg; ICE December arabica closes. Trading Economics / market reports: ICE arabica ~$2.93/lb (5 Oct 2026), 52-week range $2.44-4.23.

IndiaMART and TradeIndia listings (May-Sept 2026): bulk Chikmagalur green arabica ₹450-600/kg. Amazon.in and roaster sites: Blue Tokai Attikan ₹700 / Sandalwood ₹750 per 250 g; Subko ₹895-1,369 per 250 g; Black Baza Otter ₹580 per 250 g.

Treayo / eximpe HS-code pages: India BCD 100% on HS 0901 coffee, IGST 5%, SWS 10% (verify with CBIC). FSSAI advisory (Nov 2021): coffee-chicory mix must contain at least 51% coffee and declare the split.

Business Today, Daily Pioneer, Zee Business (May 2026): Amul +₹2/L; Amul Gold ₹70/L, Taaza ₹57/L. PIB and Drishti IAS: Indian coffee GI tags.

Counter Culture Coffee and Coffee Board research notes: S.795 (Sln 3), Sln 9, Chandragiri (Sln 13), Cauvery parentage. Roaster and producer pages: Ratnagiri, Kerehaklu, Baarbara and Attikan estate details. The Week (Apr 2025): Badra Estates, Flavour of India award.

District blog 'Speciality Coffee Spots in Ahmedabad' (23 Sept 2026); Swiggy, Zomato, EazyDiner, Wanderlog and Justdial listings; r/ahmedabad discussion; Curly Tales and Retail4Growth (Third Wave Ahmedabad launch, Nov 2025); Restaurant India and Tata Consumer (Tata Starbucks sourcing).

Limitations: direct access to several sites was blocked during research, so some figures come from search-index excerpts. Prices move daily, and ratings are informed opinion. Verify current prices with suppliers before committing capital.